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factions of uncle and nephew has made it evident that the split may be as personal as it is political. When Ajit age-shamed the 82-year-old Pawar, and called for his retirement, Sule, without naming her cousin, warned against crossing that line: "Don't attack my father...we will tolerate anything, but not that." Pawar, too, warned that anyone "taunting him about his age will have to pay a price". Ajit also revealed that his uncle, who is now a key part of the efforts to cobble together a national opposition against the ruling BJP, had 'negotiated' with the same party on multiple occasions since 2014 (indeed, the first public overture was after the assembly polls that year when NCP offered "outside support" to the BJP to form a government).

In yet another indication that it was open season between the two, former Union minister Praful Patel (now in the Ajit camp) reportedly told an English daily that Sule had "become the fulcrum" of Pawar Sr's actions and that he was foisting his decisions on everyone. Patel, who was till yesterday a trusted aide of Pawar Sr, denied the comments later, but the deed was done. Ajit also staked claim to the NCP name and symbol and anointed himself party chief, all of which has been hotly contested by the Sharad Pawar faction.

THE WAR OF WORDS BETWEEN THE FACTIONS OF PAWAR SR AND NEPHEW AJIT HAS MADE IT EVIDENT THAT THE SPLIT MAY BE AS PERSONAL AS IT IS POLITICAL

Till the rebellion happened, the Pawars, one of Maharashtra's prominent political families, were considered a close-knit group. Differences were ironed out with the mediation of Pawar Sr, the patriarch of the extended clan. However, Ajit's rebellion, and his claiming support of around 40 of the 53 NCP legislators, has disrupted this delicate status quo.

The Pawar family's tryst with politics started with a somewhat similar disruption in 1960 when a 20-year-old Sharad Pawar, then a budding Youth Congress leader on the make, found himself at odds with the political ambitions of his eldest brother Vasantrao. In 1960, Vasantrao had been nominated by the Peasants and Workers Party (PWP) and the opposition Samyukta Maharashtra Samiti to contest the bypolls from the Baramati Lok Sabha constituency after the death of incumbent MP Keshavrao Jedhe, a doyen of the non-Brahmin movement. This was the first byelection after the formation of '*samyukta* Maharashtra' or the Marathi-speaking state of Maharashtra with Mumbai as the capital, and was hence a prestige battle. Vasantrao, a lawyer and the eldest of the 11 Pawar siblings—Sharad was No. 8—was well respected as he had taken great pains to ensure that all of them got a good education. The family, including father Govindrao and mother Sharadabai, was rooting for the PWP and Vasantrao, so there was some consternation over young Sharad canvassing for the Congress. But his parents, and Vasantrao too, gave him the go-ahead. In the end, Vasantrao lost the election but Sharad's stock rose in the Congress and in the eyes of mentor and then chief minister, Y.B. Chavan. In 1967, Pawar was elected MLA from Baramati, which soon became his pocket borough. Under his care, the region has become an agricultural, educational and industrial hub.

Sixty-odd years after that first election when the family deftly avoided a schism, the Pawars are again divided. This time, Sharad Pawar is the patriarch taking on nephew Ajit, whom he himself had chosen three decades back to take on his mantle. After an estrangement with the family, Ajit's father Anantrao worked as an assistant cinematographer in Mumbai with the legendary V. Shantaram, collaborating on such masterpieces as *Jhanak Jhanak Payal Baje* and *Amar Bhupali*, before he returned to Baramati to take charge of the family's farms. He later served as vice-chairman of the Chhatrapati Cooperative Sugar factory, co-founded by their father Govindrao.

In the 1991 Lok Sabha election, the Baramati seat was up for grabs. Pawar's elder brother and constituency manager Dinkarrao a.k.a. Appasaheb was eager to contest, but Pawar chose the then 32-year-old Ajit instead. The latter was taking his first tentative steps in politics via the cooperative route (Ajit was also a director of the Chhatrapati